

Person-First Language Cheat-Sheet

A free one-pager from Edward at Caira. The short, practical version — for your notes and your everyday work.

The golden rule: ask the person how *they* describe themselves. These are general conventions for Australian disability support; individual preference and identity-first choices always win. This is guidance, not a rulebook.

Say this → not that

Lead with the person	Instead of
a person with disability	a disabled person / the disabled
uses a wheelchair	wheelchair-bound / confined to a wheelchair
a person with autism / an autistic person (<i>ask their preference</i>)	suffers from autism
has an intellectual disability	intellectually disabled / "low-functioning"
communicates using...	non-verbal (<i>as a label</i>)
receives support with...	dependent on / a burden
a person without disability	normal / able-bodied (<i>as the contrast</i>)

Principles behind it

- **Person first, condition second.** The person isn't their diagnosis.
- **Describe the support, not the deficit.** "needs support with meals", not "can't feed themselves".
- **Neutral, not pity or praise.** Avoid "suffers from", "brave", "inspiring" by default.
- **Observable, not assumed.** In notes, write what you saw — not what you guessed they felt.
- **Their words win.** Identity-first ("autistic person", "Deaf") is many people's preference. Ask.

In your notes specifically

- Factual and respectful — about the person, not the label.
- "Participant declined the activity" ✓ — not "was uncooperative" ✗
- Record support and response, not character judgements.

I built these habits into Caira so respectful, factual notes are the default, not extra work. Pre-launch — reach out if you'd like to shape it and be first in line.

Care is the work. Caira handles the record. · caira.net.au